

LADY VICTORIA
designs

Before You Book the Venue

The Essential Wedding Venue Checklist

A COMPLIMENTARY GUIDE FROM LADY VICTORIA DESIGNS

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A NOTE BEFORE YOU TOUR

The venue comes *first*

The venue is the first big decision you make, and nearly every decision after it depends on it.

Your guest count, your menu, your décor, your timeline, even the way your guests arrive: all of it has to fit inside the rules of the room you choose. A venue can be breathtaking on a tour and still be unable to support the celebration you are planning.

This checklist holds the same questions our planners ask on every venue tour. Take it with you, ask every question that applies, and do not pay a deposit until the answers that matter are in writing.



With care, Irene

IRENE NTIAKO · FOUNDER & CREATIVE DIRECTOR

THE ONE RULE

“We’re flexible” *is not a yes*

Here is how it usually happens. On the tour, you mention that your caterer will cook on-site, and the coordinator smiles and says, “We’re very flexible.” Months later, the contract arrives, and it says outside food must arrive fully prepared. Nothing was promised in writing, so nothing was promised.

BEFORE YOU SIGN

If a promise affects your ceremony, décor, food, music, parking, guest count, budget, installation, or timeline, request written confirmation in the contract.



HOW TO USE THIS CHECKLIST

Four steps, *one tour at a time*

01 **Before the tour**
Read it through and cross out anything that does not apply to your wedding.

02 **On the tour**
Ask each question. Write down the answer and the name of the person who gave it.

03 **After the tour**
Ask the venue to confirm the important answers by email or in the contract. You don't need every answer confirmed, just the ones that affect your plans.

04 **Before you sign**
Anything not confirmed in writing becomes a change to request in the contract, or a reason to keep looking.

☐ **ASKED**
Tick when you have asked the question and noted the answer.

☐ **CONFIRMED**
Tick when the venue confirms the answer by email or in the contract.

WHAT TO BRING TO THE TOUR

- Your guest count, and the most it could grow to
- Your wedding date, or the dates you are considering
- Your budget range for the venue
- Photos of your design inspiration
- A list of your ceremonies, traditions, and must-haves
- A tape measure, and your phone for photos and video
- This checklist and a pen
- Your planner or designer, if you have one



01 Date, Hours & Curfew

Setup, the celebration, and cleanup all come out of the same rental hours.

	ASKED	CONFIRMED
What time may vendors begin load-in, and when must setup be complete?	☐	☐
What time must music, alcohol service, guest activity, and vendor load-out end?	☐	☐
What overtime fees apply to event time, staff, security, cleanup, or late strike?	☐	☐
Is there a local noise ordinance or amplified-sound limit that ends outdoor music earlier than the venue curfew?	☐	☐

02 Real Capacity & Layout

The capacity on the brochure is usually for an empty room. Your dance floor, stage, bars, and décor all take seats away.

	ASKED	CONFIRMED
What is the realistic seated capacity with tables, stage, dance floor, entertainment, bars, food stations, lounge furniture, and cultural structures?	☐	☐
Can the full guest count fit in the weather-backup space?	☐	☐
If weather forces a change, by what time must the call be made, and are tents, sidewalls, heaters, or ground flooring permitted?	☐	☐
Does capacity change for multiple ceremonies or room flips?	☐	☐

NOTES

03 Alcohol, Bar & Certificates

Whoever holds the license decides who pours, who is insured, and when the bar closes.

	ASKED	CONFIRMED
Does the venue hold the required liquor license, or is a temporary permit needed?	☐	☐
Who obtains the permit, licensed bartenders, security, liquor-liability coverage, and certificate of insurance?	☐	☐
Must the venue be named as an additional insured?	☐	☐
What time must alcohol service end, and what bar fees apply?	☐	☐

04 Catering & Kitchen Rules

If your caterer cannot cook the way your menu needs, the meal you are picturing may not be possible here.

	ASKED	CONFIRMED
Is catering exclusive, preferred-list only, or open to outside cultural caterers?	☐	☐
May caterers cook on-site, and are tandoors, grills, fryers, woks, propane, refrigeration, water, ice, and waste disposal permitted?	☐	☐
Can halal, kosher, Jain, vegetarian, vegan, allergy, fasting, and cross-contact requirements be supported?	☐	☐

NOTES

05 In-House Rentals

"Included" can mean anything. Ask exactly what, how many, and in what condition.

	ASKED	CONFIRMED
Which tables, chairs, linens, tabletop items, bars, staging, dance floors, lounge pieces, and cocktail tables are included?	☐	☐
What quantities, sizes, colors, and conditions are guaranteed?	☐	☐
Are delivery, setup, breakdown, cleaning, reset, and damage fees included?	☐	☐
May the dance floor be wrapped or covered with a custom vinyl wrap or overlay? What adhesive, installation, removal, and floor-protection rules apply, and who is liable for damage to the floor beneath?	☐	☐

06 Décor Setup, Load-In & Breakdown Access

Your design is only as good as the hours, doors, and elevators you get to install it.

	ASKED	CONFIRMED
Exactly how many hours are allowed for décor setup before guest arrival?	☐	☐
Exactly how many hours are allowed for décor breakdown and load-out?	☐	☐
Can installation begin the day before, and may décor remain overnight?	☐	☐
Is the space on the same level as the loading entrance?	☐	☐
Is there a loading dock, same-level entry, ramp, or service entrance for large pieces?	☐	☐
What are the freight-elevator interior dimensions, door opening, weight limit, and reservation rules?	☐	☐
Can oversized backdrops, stages, floral installations, carts, and rental furniture fit through every door, hallway, turn, and elevator?	☐	☐

NOTES

06 Décor Setup, Load-In & Breakdown Access *continued*

	ASKED	CONFIRMED
How far is the loading point from the event space, and are there stairs, narrow corridors, carpet, or guest areas on the route?	☐	☐
Are dock times assigned, and can multiple vendors load in together?	☐	☐
Where may décor trucks and production vehicles park after unloading?	☐	☐
Are union labor, venue engineers, security, or venue staff required?	☐	☐
What carts, dollies, lifts, ladders, scissor lifts, forklifts, or pallet jacks are allowed?	☐	☐
When must the room be guest-ready, and who approves room release?	☐	☐
What happens if access is delayed by the venue or a prior event?	☐	☐
What dock, elevator, storage, cleanup, overtime, or late-strike fees apply?	☐	☐
Where may boxes, tools, floral buckets, packaging, and production cases be stored?	☐	☐
Who performs the final walkthrough, and how are damages recorded?	☐	☐
Are real-flame candles permitted (including floating and votive candles), and what glass-enclosure or venue approval rules apply?	☐	☐
What may be attached to walls, ceilings, and floors — and are tape, pins, hooks, confetti, loose petals, or sparklers restricted?	☐	☐

NOTES

07 Power, Rigging & Effects

Lighting, music, chandeliers, and first-dance effects all need power and permission, and both run out.

	ASKED	CONFIRMED
How much electrical power is available for lighting, entertainment, catering, and production, and where are the circuits and outlets located?	☐	☐
Are dedicated circuits, a power drop, or a generator required or provided, and what do they cost?	☐	☐
May chandeliers, florals, draping, or installations be hung from the ceiling? What rigging points, weight limits, and rigger requirements apply?	☐	☐
Are cold-spark machines permitted for entrances and first-dance moments, and what fire-marshal, insurance, or venue approvals apply?	☐	☐
Is a low-lying cloud effect (dry ice) permitted for the first dance? What rules apply to dry-ice delivery, storage, and handling, ventilation, and fire-alarm or smoke-detector sensitivity?	☐	☐
Is atmospheric haze permitted for lighting and photography effects?	☐	☐
If the venue loses power, is there backup power, and what happens to the event?	☐	☐



08 Guest Parking, Valet & Arrival

Arrival is your guests' first impression. A long walk in the rain is hard to undo.

	ASKED	CONFIRMED
How many guest parking spaces are available?	☐	☐
Is parking complimentary, validated, or paid by guests?	☐	☐
Is valet required or optional, and what are the fee, minimum, staffing, hours, and gratuity rules?	☐	☐
Where are the guest drop-off, accessible drop-off, shuttle, bus, limousine, and rideshare areas?	☐	☐
Is overflow parking available, and is a shuttle required?	☐	☐
Can vendor vehicles park separately from guests?	☐	☐
Are there garage height limits, operating hours, traffic restrictions, or overnight-parking rules?	☐	☐
Is the path from parking safe, accessible, and well lit in bad weather?	☐	☐
Can a cultural procession occur without blocking valet, guest parking, traffic, or emergency access?	☐	☐

09 Total Cost & Contract

The quote is rarely the total. Every fee you do not ask about shows up later.

	ASKED	CONFIRMED
Does the quote include rental, service charges, taxes, staffing, security, cleaning, rentals, parking, valet, power, elevators, docks, overtime, and damage deposits?	☐	☐
Does the contract list setup and breakdown hours, loading access, parking, curfew, catering, alcohol, weather, and overtime terms?	☐	☐
Will every important approval be placed in writing?	☐	☐
What deposit and payment schedule does the venue require, and what are the cancellation and postponement terms?	☐	☐
What insurance certificates must each vendor provide, and when are they due to the venue?	☐	☐

NOTES

IF YOU HEAR THIS, SLOW DOWN

Venue *Red Flags*

- "We're flexible," with no written detail behind it.
- Only an hour or two to set up décor before guests arrive.
- No one can tell you the freight-elevator or doorway measurements, or your décor will not fit.
- The weather-backup space cannot hold your full guest count.
- The quote leaves out service charges, tax, security, or overtime.
- Guest parking or valet cannot handle your guest count.
- Hanging installations, candles, or effects in your design are not permitted.
- The venue will not put an approval in the contract.

THE LAST STEP

Before You Sign

01 Request a complete itemized proposal.

02 Walk and measure the décor freight path from the truck to the event space.

03 Confirm setup and breakdown hours in the contract.

04 Confirm guest parking, valet, accessible drop-off, rideshare, shuttle, and vendor parking.

05 Review the venue with your planner, caterer, designer, and entertainment team.



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Lady Victoria Designs provides luxury wedding planning and full-room event design with thoughtful logistics, strong client advocacy, refined aesthetics, and celebrations that honor each couple's priorities and traditions.

Touring venues and want a second set of eyes? We invite you to schedule a design consultation.

Bring this checklist and your venue contract — we will review the answers with you and help you confirm the venue can support the celebration you are envisioning.

SCHEDULE A CONSULTATION

TEXT	(301) 312-0332
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